



VillageWatch

The Coordinator Guide

Everything you need to run VillageWatch for your village.
No technical knowledge is assumed.

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QUESTIONS
info@yakasista.com

Keep your village safe · villagewatch.app · Operated by Yakasista Ltd. This guide describes how the software behaves; it is not legal advice. The documents your village accepts on the compliance screen are the ones that bind it.

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The live copy of this guide is always on screen at villagewatch.app/dashboard/guide. Print this one for the parish papers or for a fellow volunteer, and check the date on the cover against the screen before you rely on a detail. Each section starts on a new page, so a single section can be pulled out and handed to somebody on its own.

Everything you need to run VillageWatch for your village. No technical knowledge is assumed. If you can run a parish noticeboard and a WhatsApp group, you can run this.

Read it once end to end before you open the village to residents. After that, treat it as a reference: the contents list will take you to the section you want.

Welcome

What VillageWatch is

VillageWatch is a way for the people who live in your village to tell each other what they have seen, without any of them having to put their name, their neighbour's name or a car registration in front of the whole village.

It lives at **villagewatch.app**. There is nothing to install — a resident opens that address in the browser they already use, and their phone will offer to add it to the home screen, after which it behaves like any other app.

A resident opens the app and describes what happened in their own words. Before anything is saved, the description is rewritten to take out the details that identify people — names, registrations, house numbers, descriptions that only fit one person. The resident reads that rewrite and either accepts it or edits it. Only then is the report filed.

If they attach a photo, faces in it are covered on their own phone, before the picture is sent anywhere. The original never leaves the device.

The location is deliberately imprecise. Every pin on the map is moved a short distance from the place that was actually reported, so a pin can tell you which end of the lane something happened at and cannot tell you which house.

What the village then gets is a map, a list of recent reports, and a phone alert when something serious is published.

What being a coordinator means

You are the person who decides what the village sees. In data protection terms somebody has to be the *data controller* — the person or body legally answerable for all of this — and which one you are depends on how your village is run.

Most villages have no parish council behind them. In that case **you** are the controller. It is not a title you apply for; it is a description of what you are already doing, and it would be true whether or not anybody wrote it down. The Community Coordinator Agreement in the next section sets out what it obliges you to do, and the compliance screen lists the three duties with a deadline on them before it asks you to accept anything.

Where a parish or town council has taken the village on, the council is the controller and you act on its behalf.

Either way VillageWatch is the *processor*: we run the software and do what the controller tells us.

That relationship is the reason for the paperwork in the next section, and it is worth understanding rather than clicking past. When a resident asks who holds their data, the answer is you or the council. When something goes wrong, that is also who the Information Commissioner writes to.

What you can do

- See every report filed in your village, including ones waiting for review and ones that were rejected.
- Publish a report to the village, or reject it.
- Read a reporter's original wording — the words they typed before the rewrite. Every time you do this it is recorded.
- Mark a report resolved, or archive an old one.
- Change your village's settings: the council's name, how strongly faces are covered, your WhatsApp Channel, and whether reports are published automatically.
- Produce a report for your police contact or a council meeting, and download a spreadsheet of the village's reports.
- Hand out the village's invite — a link, a code and a QR code you can print and pin to the noticeboard.
- See the Home Office's own recorded-crime figures for the area beside your village's reports, and your neighbourhood policing team's contact details.
- See which reports the village itself rated more serious than they look.
- Read the village's audit trail — a record of what every coordinator has done.

What you cannot do

- **See another village.** Every screen in the app shows your village and only your village. There is no view across villages and no way to ask for one.
- **Approve a resident's application to become a coordinator.** Those go to the platform administrator, not to you. See "Managing your community".
- **Change your own role, or anybody else's.** Roles are set by the system when an application is approved.
- **Change or delete the audit trail.** Nothing can, including us. That is the point of it.
- **Un-accept a compliance document, or move a village back off the council model.** Acceptances are a record of something that happened on a date, so nothing on screen can rewrite them.
- **Recover a published report.** Once a report is published, residents have seen it and may have shared it. Think of publishing as final.

Getting started

Six things, in this order. The first one is not optional — until it is done your village cannot accept a single report — and the last one is what actually puts residents in your village.

1. Accept the compliance documents

Go to **Compliance** in the sidebar, or Dashboard then Compliance.

What you see there depends on how your village is run, and most villages get the first of these two.

If there is no parish council behind your village — the community model

You will find **one** document: the **Community Coordinator Agreement**. It is written for a volunteer rather than for a clerk and takes about ten minutes.

It does two jobs. It is the contract between you and Yakasista Ltd, who run the software — a controller may only use a processor under a written contract. And it is the **policy document** the law requires before anyone may collect reports about suspected crime: reports are *criminal offence data*, which is treated more strictly than ordinary personal data, and processing it lawfully at all depends on having that document in place. Without one there is no lawful authorisation — not a paperwork gap, an actual absence of legal basis.

You are the data controller. That is a description of what you are already doing rather than a title you apply for: you decide who is invited in, what gets published and what happens to a report. Three duties come with it and the screen sets them out above the agreement — answering a resident's request within one month, reporting a serious breach within 72 hours, and keeping a record of what the village processes. Sections 2 to 5 of the agreement are that record for everything the software does, and info@yakasista.com is where to go when one of the other two actually happens.

One signature, and it is in force when you accept it. There is no paper copy waiting on a countersignature.

If a parish or town council runs your village — the council model

You will find **three** documents, shown in full. They are written for a parish councillor and between them run to a good half hour — put the kettle on.

- **The Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA).** What the service does with residents' information, what could go wrong, and what has been built to stop it. UK GDPR Article 35 requires this before high-risk processing starts, not after.
- **The Appropriate Policy Document (APD).** The same policy document described above, as a document of the council's own — which is what a council is separately obliged to hold.
- **The Data Processing Agreement (DPA).** The contract between your council and Yakasista Ltd. A council using VillageWatch without one is in breach from the first report filed.

Tick all three and press **Accept and enable village**. Your name and the date are recorded against each one, and each is written to the audit trail separately.

Either way

- **This blocks reporting until it is done.** A resident who opens the report form before you have finished this screen is told the village is not accepting reports yet and given the 999 and 101 numbers. That is deliberate.
- **It cannot be undone from this screen.** A controller that adopted a document on a date did adopt it on that date. If you or the council later want to withdraw, that is a conversation with us, not a checkbox.
- **The council's processing agreement takes two signatures and you would only be providing one.** Ticking that box records the council's acceptance of the terms; the agreement is not in force until Yakasista Ltd has signed the paper copy too. Send the signed copy to info@yakasista.com and keep the countersigned version with the council's records. The community agreement is not like this — it takes one signature and is in force when you accept it.

Take your own advice on the terms before accepting, and if a council has its own standard processing agreement, use that instead — tell us and we will sign it.

If a council takes the village on later

At the foot of the compliance screen there is a control for exactly that. It switches the village to the council model, and the council then adopts the three documents above and becomes the data controller from the date it does.

Two things worth knowing. **Your village does not close while that happens** — reporting carries on under the agreement you accepted, because you are still the controller until the council has adopted its own, and nobody should have to wait for a parish meeting to file a report. And **your acceptance is not deleted**: you were the controller for that period, and the record of it is what shows the handover was orderly. It is one-way, so if a council later steps back, talk to us rather than switching it back.

2. Set the name of whoever is answerable

Go to **Dashboard** and find the data controller field in Village Settings. It is headed **Parish council** if a council runs your village and **Data controller** if one does not, but it is the same field either way.

If a council runs your village, type its full legal name exactly as it appears on its own letterhead — "Histon and Impington Parish Council", not "Histon PC". There is no fixed format, because the real names are not uniform: parish meetings, town councils and Welsh community councils all differ.

If no council runs your village, put the name people would recognise as the group — "Histon Neighbourhood Watch", or your own name if that is what the village would recognise. The field is free text and is not validated against anything.

This name is printed at the foot of every document the app produces for your police contact or the council, and it is who a resident is told to take a data protection complaint to. Get it wrong and a subject access request goes somewhere with no authority to answer it.

Do this before the first report is filed, not after.

3. Choose how strongly faces are covered

Also on the Dashboard. Four options, and there is a small preview of each one next to it.

Level	What it does	When to use it
Light blur	The softest option. Keeps the most of the scene around the face.	Only if your police contact has specifically asked for it.
Standard blur	The default. Faces unreadable; you can still see how many people there were and where they stood.	Almost every village, almost all of the time.
Heavy blur	A wider smear that also takes hair, build and clothing at the collar.	A village that has had a complaint, or one where people know each other well enough to recognise a coat.
Full redact	A solid black rectangle over the face. Nothing of it is left in the file.	The most cautious setting, and the one to choose if you are unsure.

Two things about this that are easy to misread:

- **Every level covers every face.** The scale does not decide *whether* a face is hidden — it decides how much of the surroundings go with it. Even the lightest setting destroys the face itself; you cannot accidentally set this to "leave people recognisable".
- **It applies to photos added after you change it.** A photo a resident has already attached keeps the treatment it was given when it was processed. The reporter's screen says so.

A reporter can always ask for *more* covering than you have set — there is a checkbox on the upload that blacks a face out completely. There is deliberately no way for a reporter to ask for less.

If you have a police contact, ask them what they would prefer before you choose. Some forces would rather have a lightly blurred image they can work with; most would rather you did not collect the photograph at all.

4. Set up your WhatsApp Channel

Optional, and most villages want only the first half of this.

A WhatsApp Channel is the broadcast kind — you post, followers read, nobody can reply and followers cannot see each other. It is not a group chat. If your village does not have one, you create it inside WhatsApp itself in about a minute.

Once you have one, open WhatsApp, go to the channel, and copy its invite link. Paste that link into the WhatsApp Channel field on the Dashboard. That is all you have to do — the app works the rest out from the link.

What that gets you:

- Every resident's Settings screen gains a **Follow on WhatsApp** button, so people can find the channel without you posting the link again every month.
- When you approve a report, a ready-made alert appears with a **Copy to WhatsApp** button next to it. Press it, open the channel, paste.

Nothing is posted automatically, ever. There is no robot with access to your channel. Every message that appears there was pasted by a person who had just read the report. This is a deliberate design decision, not a missing feature: the channel is the one place where what you post can be read by someone who is not a resident of your village, and we would rather a human made that call every time.

There are two switches beside the field. One turns channel alerts on for the village, and one sets the lowest severity worth an alert — it starts at High, which is stricter than the phone alerts residents get, because a channel is public and phone alerts are not.

5. Decide about auto-approve

The last setting, and the biggest one. It is **off** by default.

With auto-approve **off**, every report a resident files waits in a queue until you look at it. You get a phone alert when something arrives. Nothing reaches the village map until you press Approve.

With auto-approve **on**, reports are published the moment they are filed. The phone alert goes out, the pin appears on the map, and the first you know about it is the same time as everybody else.

Turning it on removes the only person standing between a resident's submission and the whole village. The rewrite that takes out identifying details is good, but it is not moderation — it cannot tell that a report is a neighbour dispute, or malicious, or about a child.

Reasonable villages choose either. Turn it on if:

- your village is small and you know everybody who has joined;
- reports are rare enough that a day in the queue is a real delay; and
- you have read what a report looks like when the rewrite did not run, which is the case that catches people out — when the rewrite is unavailable, what gets published is the reporter's own words.

Keep it off if you are new to this, if the village is large, or if you have any reason to expect reports about identifiable individuals.

Two more things:

- **Turning it on does not empty the queue.** Reports already waiting were filed under a promise that somebody would look at them, and some of them are sitting there because you had doubts. The queue stays; the setting applies to what is filed next.
- **Auto-approve and WhatsApp Channel posting together are a big step.** It means an unreviewed report is one paste away from the open internet. Nothing stops you doing it, and you should do it knowingly. If you file a report yourself in an auto-approving village, you land on a screen with the alert already on it, having just read what it says.

Every one of these settings is recorded in the audit trail with your name against it.

6. Invite the village

Nothing above puts a single resident in your village. This does.

At the foot of the Dashboard there is an invite panel holding four versions of the same invitation, all built from the same link so they cannot come apart:

- **The link.** villagewatch.app/join/your-village?code=XXXXXX. Somebody who opens it sees your village's name and what they are joining before they are asked for anything, then goes on to register with the village and the code already filled in.
- **The join code on its own**, for reading down the phone or printing in a newsletter next to the plain address.
- **A WhatsApp message**, prewritten, for pasting into the group the village already uses.
- **A QR code**, with a **Download** button for a poster and a **Print** button that produces a one-page invite sheet — the code, the village name and three steps, and nothing else on the paper.

Print one sheet and look at it before you print a hundred. The join code is printed as text beside the QR on purpose, because a camera that will not focus is common and typing six characters is the fallback.

If the panel says the village has no join code yet, it has not been activated. Email info@yakasista.com — that is our job, not yours.

See "How residents join" for where to put all this.

Managing incidents

The moderation queue

If auto-approve is off, this is the daily work. It is on the Dashboard, under the figures.

Each report in the queue shows you the title, the anonymised description, the type and severity, when and roughly where it happened, and any photo. That is enough to make the decision in most cases.

Read it as a resident would. The question is not "is this true" — you often cannot know — but "should the village see this, in these words".

Approving

Press **Approve**. Four things happen at once:

1. The report appears on the village map and in the incident list, and stays there for twelve months.
2. A phone alert goes out to residents who have notifications on, whose severity threshold this report meets, and who live close enough to it. Anybody whose home location is unknown gets the alert — a distance filter is a way to hear less, not a reason to be silently left out.
3. The reporter is told their report was published.
4. If your village has a WhatsApp Channel set up, an alert appears on screen with a copy button, ready to paste.

An entry goes in the audit trail with your name on it.

Approving is not reversible. You can archive a report afterwards, which takes it off the map, but the alert has already gone out and residents have already read it.

Rejecting

Press **Reject**, with a note.

The note is not optional, and it is not for you — it is quoted back to the reporter. A rejection with nothing after it tells a volunteer nothing about whether they should have reported it, whether to try again, or whether they have done something wrong. "Please report this to 101 first — we can add it here once you have a crime number" is a note. "Rejected" is not.

Reject when:

- **It is an emergency.** Someone is in danger, or a crime is happening now. Reject it and tell them to call 999. The app is not a way of contacting the police.
- **It is a dispute between two neighbours.** These are almost never improved by publication, and the village map is the worst possible venue for one.

- **It identifies somebody anyway.** The rewrite catches names and registrations. It cannot catch "the man at the house with the blue door", and in a village of four hundred people that is an identification.
- **It is speculation presented as fact.** "A silver car went past twice" is a report. "There's a gang casing the village" is not.
- **It is about a child,** unless it plainly needs to be there.
- **It is not a community safety matter at all** — a planning grievance, a parking row, a dog.

Rejecting does not delete the report. It stays in the system, visible to you and to the reporter, and out of sight of everybody else. If you want it gone entirely, the reporter can delete it, and so can you.

Resolving and archiving

A published report can be marked **Resolved** when the matter is closed — the bike was found, the police attended, the fly-tipping was cleared. It stays visible, marked as resolved. This is worth doing: a map full of unresolved reports reads as a village where nothing ever gets sorted out.

Archive takes a report off the map and out of the list. Use it for something that has stopped being useful — a report about a road closure that has since reopened, or a duplicate of another report.

You do not have to archive things to keep the map tidy. Published reports are archived automatically after twelve months, and photographs are deleted after six, whether or not anybody touches them.

Reading the reporter's original wording

In the queue there is a button marked **Show the reporter's original wording**. It shows you what the resident actually typed, before the identifying details were taken out.

Use it sparingly, and only when the decision in front of you genuinely turns on it. Reasonable uses: the anonymised version is incoherent and you cannot tell what happened; you suspect the report is malicious; the police have asked a specific question.

Every single press is recorded — your name, the report, the time — and other coordinators in your village can see that record on the audit trail, as can we. That is not a threat, it is the design. The reporter's own words are the most sensitive thing in the system, and the only thing that makes it safe to let anybody read them is that nobody can read them quietly.

Never copy those words anywhere. Not into an email, not into WhatsApp, not into a text to your PCSO. See "Privacy responsibilities".

After twelve months there is nothing to show. When a report is archived on its twelfth birthday, the reporter's original wording is deleted in the same step — permanently, from us as well as from you. Pressing the button on an older report tells you the wording is gone rather than showing you anything, and that press is deliberately not recorded, because an entry saying a coordinator read somebody's words when there were no words to read is a worse record than none. The anonymised description stays.

Reading your village

The moderation queue is the work. This section is the part that tells you whether the work is achieving anything, and it is what you take to a parish meeting.

The period, and the three screens that share it

The Dashboard, the incident list and the map each have a period control at the top: last 7 days, last 30 days, and so on, with **Custom range** opening a calendar if you want two specific dates.

It is one control governing everything on the screen below it. Change the period on the Dashboard and the figures, the breakdowns, the hotspots and the official police figures all move together — there is no card quietly showing a different window from the one you selected.

The period is in the address bar, which is more useful than it sounds. Once you have the report you want, bookmark it, or send the link to a fellow coordinator and they see exactly what you see.

The Dashboard deliberately has no "all time" option. Every figure on it is a comparison against the period immediately before, and there is no period before all time.

The Dashboard figures

Two numbers at the top. How many reports were published in the period, and how many of them were High or Critical. Each carries its change against the preceding period of the same length — thirty days against the thirty before it — so "eleven reports" becomes "eleven reports, up from four".

Two breakdowns. *What was reported* by category, and *How serious* by severity. Plain bars, no chart library, and they print.

Where it keeps happening. The three most reported places in the period, counted by the landmark residents typed, with a small density map of the same period above the list.

Read those two together, because each covers the other's blind spot. The list counts words, so "Mill Lane" and "the bus stop on Mill Lane" are two rows and one place, and a report filed with no landmark at all is in neither. The map is the same period read off the map pins instead, so it knows nothing about what anybody typed.

What the village makes of a report

Every published report carries two small buttons and a number — a thumbs up and a thumbs down — on the incident list and on the report's own page. Any resident of your village can press them.

Up means "this matters more than it looks". Down means "less". The severity on a report is the reporter's own assessment of what they saw. This is everybody else's, and it is the only signal in the app that comes from neither the person who filed the report nor the person who reviewed it.

It is a toggle with three states, and the third is having pressed nothing. Pressing the button you already pressed removes your vote. Pressing the other one changes your mind. One resident holds one opinion of one report.

A vote moves nothing. It does not change a report's severity, its status or who it was sent to; it publishes nothing and it wakes nobody's phone up. That restraint is deliberate rather than unfinished. Severity decides who gets a phone alert and whether a report clears the WhatsApp Channel's threshold, so a control that moved it would let a handful of taps decide who gets woken at night — and the obvious failure is not malice, it is a popular report about a lost dog outranking an unpopular one about a neighbour.

Nobody is named, anywhere. There is no screen in the app that says who voted which way — not for a resident, not for you, and not for us. What every surface carries is two counts. In a village, "who thought my report was overblown" is a question with consequences at the school gate, and the answer is deliberately not available. If a resident closes their account or deletes a report, the votes attached to it go with it.

What it is for is the panel on your Dashboard. It lists the reports your village actually voted on, and you can order it three ways:

Ordering	What it shows you
Most concerning	Reports the village rated more serious than they look. This is the one to read first.
Most voted on	Reports the most neighbours had a view about, in either direction. A report six people disagreed about is worth your attention whatever the net figure.
Rated less serious	Reports the village thinks were overstated. Useful, and easy to over-read — see below.

Reports nobody voted on are simply absent. They are unrated rather than uninteresting, and padding the list with them would turn an ordering into a ranking of things nobody ranked.

Read it as what it is: a show of hands, not evidence. A quiet lane with three elderly residents will never out-vote a busy close with forty, and the "rated less serious" list is at least as likely to be telling you that a report was badly worded as that it was overstated. It is a prompt to go and look, and it is a genuinely good one — it is the only thing on the Dashboard that tells you what your village is worried about rather than what it filed.

The period report you send your PCSO carries a **Most concerning to residents** section built from the same votes, and it is bounded: a report needs at least two votes to appear at all, so one neighbour nudging something never leads a document addressed to a police officer. The section is left out entirely when nothing qualifies, and it carries a sentence explaining that these are residents' opinions rather than a severity assessment — and, in particular, that seven votes is seven opinions and not seven witnesses. Leave that sentence in when you quote from it.

The map

Map in the sidebar draws every published report in the period. A control in the corner switches between **Pins**, **Heatmap** and **Both**, and your choice is remembered on that device.

Pins are one report each, coloured by severity. The heatmap is the one to show a meeting: it weighs each report by how serious it was and how recent, so a corner with four moderate reports this month burns brighter than one serious report last spring. That is the property you want — it shows accumulation rather than drama.

Two things to hold on to when you are pointing at it. **Every point has been moved.** Coordinates are jittered before they are stored, so a blob means "around here" and never "this house" — which is all the underlying data supports, and it is deliberate. And **the heatmap is not the pattern detector**; it is a picture. The detector is the next section and it works against the database.

When a report looks like a pattern

Some reports carry a line saying something like *"3rd report of vehicle crime within 200m in the last 30 days."* That is the pattern detector, and it is worth knowing exactly what it does, because residents will ask.

It looks at **published reports only**, within **200 metres** of the new one, in the **last 30 days**. Two previous reports of the same kind makes it a repeat. Four previous reports of any kind makes it a hotspot. One previous report is a coincidence and it says nothing — a line that appeared every time would be a line everybody learned to skip.

Published only, and that matters: a note describing something still sitting in your queue would leak an unreviewed report to the resident who triggered it.

The note is not an accusation and it is not intelligence. It is arithmetic about reports your village has already seen, and it is the single most useful thing to quote to a PCSO, because it is specific, dated and bounded.

The weekly summary

Every Sunday morning the service reads the week's published reports for your village, writes a summary of them, flags anything that looks like a cluster, and sends it to the village's coordinators as a **phone notification**. Tapping it opens the Dashboard.

Three things about it:

- **It goes to coordinators only.** It ignores the severity threshold and the distance radius residents set for themselves, because those are how a resident asks to hear less village news, and this is work rather than news.
- **It arrives as a notification and nowhere else.** There is no weekly-summary screen yet. If you dismiss it, the reports it describes are all still on the Dashboard for the same period — you have lost the paragraph, not the data.
- **It still arrives when the AI is unavailable,** assembled by counting instead, and it says which of the two you are holding. An outage should not be mistakeable for a quiet week.

The habit worth forming is in "Tips and good practice": skim it on Sunday, and if there is something in it, send your PCSO the period report on the Monday.

Police recorded crime

Underneath your village's own figures, the Dashboard shows the **Home Office's** figures for the same months — every crime recorded by your force within about a mile of the village centre, published as open data at data.police.uk.

This is the panel that answers the hardest question you will be asked at a parish meeting: *is this actually getting worse, or are we just reporting more of it?* Your own numbers cannot answer it, because they move with how many residents have installed the app. The police series does not.

The two counts sit side by side and are never added together, averaged, or drawn on one chart. That is a deliberate refusal, and the caveat printed between them says why:

	What it counts	Over what area	When
Police figures	Crimes an officer recorded after a decision	About a mile around the village centre	Published about two months in arrears
VillageWatch	What a resident thought they saw at the time	Your village	Immediately

They are two different measurements of the same place, not the same measurement twice. A police "burglary" and a VillageWatch "burglary" are not the same claim. Quote both, quote the caveat with them, and do not let anybody in the room subtract one from the other.

Missing months are stated rather than shown as zero. If the most recent month of your period has not been published yet, the panel says so in as many words. A quiet-looking figure that is really an unpublished one is exactly the sort of thing that gets carried into a meeting as fact.

Your neighbourhood policing team appears in the same panel where the force publishes one: the team name, the officers with their ranks, an email address, a phone number and a link to the force's own page. It is filled in automatically from the force's own list, so it is as current as they keep it. This is the fastest way to find out who your actual PCSO is, and it saves the annual ritual of discovering they moved on eight months ago.

Two more things. **No resident data leaves the country to fetch any of this** — the request carries your village's map centre and a calendar month, and nothing else. And **the figures refresh themselves weekly**; there is no button, because the numbers are the same for everybody in the village and change once a month.

The figures are Crown copyright under the Open Government Licence, and the acknowledgement printed under the panel has to travel with them wherever you reproduce them. It is already in the period report.

If your village has no police panel at all, no figures have been collected for it yet. Tell us and we will look.

The audit trail

Dashboard, then **Audit trail**. Every action any coordinator has taken in your village, newest first, filterable by what kind of action it was, and paginated.

What is in it: reports filed, published, rejected, resolved, archived and edited; every reveal of a reporter's original wording; every village setting changed and by whom; every spreadsheet exported and every police report generated; every compliance document accepted; and every account closure and report deletion.

Nothing can edit it or delete from it. Not you, not another coordinator, not us — the database itself refuses, which is the only version of that promise worth making.

It is not there because anybody is suspected. It is there because it is what makes it safe to let a coordinator read a neighbour's original words at all, and because when a resident or the Information Commissioner asks what happened to a report, it is the answer. Read it once a quarter — see "Tips and good practice" for why that is worth doing and what to say about it.

Sharing with police and the council

Everything in this section carries the anonymised description. None of it carries the reporter's original wording, the reporter's identity, home addresses, or exact coordinates. That is a property of how the documents are built, not something you have to remember to check.

One report

Open a published report and press **Share with police**. Your phone or computer offers its usual share options — email, message, whatever you use. If sharing is not available, the summary is copied to your clipboard instead.

Available on published reports only. If you want your police contact to have a report that is still in the queue, approve it first. That is a decision, and it leaves a record.

The summary includes a link back to the report, which needs a signed-in resident of your village to open. Your PCSO will not be able to follow it unless they are one. That is intentional; the summary itself carries what they need.

A period report

Go to **Reports** in the sidebar. Choose a date range — the last week and the last month are the usual ones — and you get a document covering every report published in that period: how many, of what kind, how serious, where the clusters are, and a log of the individual reports with their references. Where residents have voted on any of them it also carries a **Most concerning to residents** section — see "What the village makes of a report" above, and keep the sentence under it when you quote from the list.

Where official figures are held for those months, the document carries a **police recorded crime** section too — the Home Office's own count for the area beside your village's, with the caveat that has to travel with the pair and the licence acknowledgement. See "Police recorded crime" above before you quote from it, and never let the two counts be read as one measurement.

There is a button that writes a narrative summary of the period in prose, suitable for reading out or forwarding. It is a separate button because it costs something to produce, and because you should be able to change the dates half a dozen times without spending it. If that summary is unavailable, the report still works — it says plainly that the figures were assembled by counting rather than written, so nobody mistakes an outage for a quiet month.

Download PDF gives you the report as a file, built by the service rather than by your browser — so the copy you send this month looks like the one you sent last month, whatever device you are on. If you have written the narrative summary, the PDF is written fresh as you download it, so its wording may differ from the paragraph on screen; **Copy report** is the one that keeps exactly what you are looking at.

Generating a period report is recorded in the audit trail. Producing a document that leaves the village is the act worth recording; looking at the dashboard figures is not.

The spreadsheet

On the Dashboard, **Export CSV** downloads your village's reports as a spreadsheet: reference, date, type, severity, status, the anonymised description, the approximate location description.

This is the one for a council meeting — paste it into a spreadsheet, make a chart of it, count the burglaries by quarter.

It deliberately does **not** contain the reporters' original wording. One report read on screen with a record of the read is a controlled act; a spreadsheet is emailed, forwarded and left on a laptop, and a name in one cannot be recalled. Nor does it contain coordinates, reporter identities or home addresses.

Deleted reports are excluded. Treat the file as council information: keep it where the council keeps its other papers, and do not forward it to a residents' group.

Managing your community

How residents join

Your village has a join code — six characters, no easily confused letters, designed to be read aloud down the phone or printed in a newsletter.

A resident goes to **villagewatch.app/register**, finds your village in the list, and enters that code. It is the code that says they were invited by the village rather than having simply found it. They can also arrive by scanning your QR code or following your invite link, in which case the village and the code are already filled in and there is nothing for them to type.

Everything you need to do that is the invite panel at the foot of the Dashboard — see "Invite the village" in Getting started.

Get the address and the code to residents the way you already reach them: the parish newsletter, the noticeboard, the existing WhatsApp group, the annual meeting. The address is public and can go anywhere. The code is not a secret in the password sense — it is a way of keeping out somebody two counties away who liked the look of the map — but do not post it on a public website.

If a code gets somewhere it should not, ask us to issue a new one. Everybody already signed up stays signed up; only new joiners need the new code.

Two emails arrive when somebody joins, and neither is from you. One is the confirmation with the link they have to click before they can sign in — that one comes from the sign-in system and is the one to ask about if somebody says they never got in. The other is a welcome from VillageWatch explaining what happens to a report once it is filed. Neither carries your address, and there is nothing you have to send.

If a resident says no email arrived, check the obvious thing first (spam), then tell us. There is a limit on how many of those the service can send in an hour, and a village onboarding twenty households in one evening can reach it — they are not locked out, they need to try again a little later, and it is worth knowing before you spend an evening troubleshooting a spelling.

Signing up in an evening is the best predictor of a village that sticks. Run it at an event where people already are — the annual meeting, the fete, the Christmas fair — with the QR sheet on the table and your phone in your hand. Twenty people who joined together talk to each other about it afterwards; twenty people who joined over four months do not.

Coordinator applications

A resident who wants to help moderate applies from their own Settings screen. They give their standing in the village — parish councillor, Neighbourhood Watch coordinator, and so on — and their reasons.

You do not approve these. They go to the platform administrator, who decides and notifies the applicant. This is not a judgement about coordinators; it is that the same screen has to work for a village that does not have a coordinator yet, and a village-appointed reviewer could only ever be somebody who already holds the role being applied for.

What you should do is the part the software cannot: know who is applying. If you want somebody appointed, email info@yakasista.com and say so. A word from the existing coordinator is the strongest thing an application can have behind it, and it is much faster than waiting for us to work out who is who.

Two or three coordinators is a good number for a village. One is a single point of failure — holidays, illness, moving away — and more than about four means nobody feels responsible for the queue.

Handling inappropriate reports

Most of what arrives is fine. For the rest:

- **Reject it with a note** that explains what would have made it acceptable. Most bad reports are a well-meaning resident misjudging the tone.
- **If a resident repeatedly files reports that identify people**, talk to them directly. This is a village; a conversation works better than a rejection note, and they are usually trying to be helpful.
- **If a report is about a specific named person and reads as harassment**, reject it and tell us. Do not leave it in the queue and do not discuss it in the village WhatsApp group.
- **If a resident asks you to take their own report down**, take it down. See the next section.
- **If somebody is using the app to threaten or target another resident**, that is a police matter and a matter for us. Contact both.

When to contact us

Email info@yakasista.com for:

- A resident who should be made a coordinator, or one who should not be any more.
- A join code that needs replacing.
- A resident who wants their account closed and cannot do it themselves.
- A subject access request, or any letter from the Information Commissioner. Tell us the same day. There are statutory deadlines on these and they are short.
- Anything that looks like a data breach — an alert that went out with a name in it, a photograph where a face was not covered, a report visible to somebody who should not see it. Same day, and before you try to fix it yourself. We may have 72 hours to report it.
- Anything you are unsure about. There is no such thing as a silly question here and there is such a thing as a late one.

Privacy responsibilities

This is the section to reread every few months.

You are handling other people's personal data

You are not a moderator on a website. Every report in your queue is a resident's personal data, held under a legal authorisation, and somebody is answerable for it.

Which somebody depends on how your village is run, and it is the same split as the compliance documents in Getting started. Where a parish or town council has taken the village on, the council is the data controller and you are acting on its behalf. Where there is no council — which is most villages — **you are the controller**, and there is nobody above you to catch a mistake. If you are not sure which you are, the answer is on the compliance screen and in section 1 of the privacy notice at villagewatch.app/privacy.

That changes who answers for what. It does not change any of the rules in this section, which apply identically either way.

Practically, all of it comes down to one test: if you would not do it with a folder of paper reports from your neighbours, do not do it here.

Never take original wording out of the app

The single most important rule in this guide.

When you press the button to see a reporter's original words, those words are for the decision in front of you. They do not go into an email to a councillor, a WhatsApp message to a PCSO, a text to another coordinator, or a note in your own files.

The anonymised version is the one that leaves the app. Everything the app builds for sharing carries that version and cannot carry the other one. The only way the original gets out is if a person copies it out, and you are that person.

Do not screenshot and forward

A screenshot bypasses everything. The moderation queue on your screen shows detail the village never sees, and a photograph of your screen in a WhatsApp group is the same disclosure as publishing it, without the record.

Use the sharing buttons. They exist so that you never have to take a screenshot, and they produce a document that is safe to send.

The same goes for the map with pins on it, and the spreadsheet.

Respect a request to delete

A resident can delete their own report at any time, and close their account. This is their right under UK GDPR Article 17 and it is not conditional on you agreeing that it is reasonable.

If someone asks you to remove a report they filed, point them at the delete button on their own report, or delete it for them. Do it promptly. If they want their whole account gone, that is on their Settings screen.

Deleting is thorough — the report's contents are erased, including the original wording, and any photograph is deleted from storage. What survives is an empty record that the report once existed, because the audit trail refers to it and the trail cannot be edited.

A published report that is deleted has still been seen. Do not promise a resident that deletion unwinds publication, because it does not.

Review the documents once a year

Whatever your village accepted is due for review a year after the date it was accepted — the Community Coordinator Agreement, or the DPIA and the Appropriate Policy Document. Put it in the diary now, or in the council's calendar; the same meeting each year is easiest.

Reviewing means reading them again and asking whether they still describe what is happening: has the village changed the privacy level, turned auto-approve on, started posting to a WhatsApp Channel, grown by three hundred people. If the answer is yes, the assessment needs to say so.

For a council that review is a council act recorded in its minutes and a fresh signature on the paper document. For a community village it is you re-reading the agreement and telling us if anything in it has stopped being true. Either way, tell us and we will send updated copies.

Tips and good practice

Put the WhatsApp Channel link where people already are. The channel is only worth having if people follow it, and nobody joins a channel they have to search for. Post the link in the existing village WhatsApp group, the Facebook group, the newsletter and the noticeboard, and post it again in three months. Most residents will follow the channel long before they install the app, and that is fine — the channel is the reach and the app is the record.

Teach the village to report facts, not theories. The most useful report is the dullest one: a white van, no markings, parked outside the recreation ground for forty minutes at about half past two, drove off towards the main road. The least useful one names somebody. If you say this often enough in the first three months, it sets the tone for good. A line in the newsletter — "please say what you saw, not who you think it was" — does most of the work.

Use the weekly summary to brief your PCSO. Every Sunday morning the app sends you the week's reports for your village and flags anything that looks like a pattern — several similar reports close together in space and time. Skim it, and if there is something in it, send the period report to your police contact on the Monday. Regular, boring, well-formatted contact with a named officer is worth far more than an urgent email once a year. The officer's name and address are on the Dashboard — see "Police recorded crime".

Take both sets of figures to the parish meeting, never one. Somebody will ask whether crime is up. Your own figures cannot answer that on their own, because they move with how many people have installed the app — six months of recruitment looks exactly like a crime wave. The Home Office panel is the independent half. Read both out, read the caveat out with them, and resist the temptation to tidy them into a single number; the honest answer to "is it getting worse" is sometimes "we cannot tell yet, and here is why".

Check the queue twice a day if auto-approve is off. Morning and evening is plenty. A report that sits for two days is a resident who concludes that nobody is reading, and they do not file the next one. If you cannot manage twice a day, that is a good reason to appoint a second coordinator — or to turn auto-approve on deliberately, having read the warnings, rather than leaving reports to languish.

Ask your police contact about the privacy level. They may have a view, and if they do it is better informed than a guess. In the absence of one, leave it on the standard blur.

Look at the audit trail occasionally. Not because you suspect anybody, but because a record nobody ever reads is a record that is not doing its job. Once a quarter is enough, and it is a reasonable thing to mention in a council report: "the trail shows four occasions on which a coordinator viewed an original report, all in connection with rejections".

Do not let it become the village's emergency number. Say it at the start, say it in the newsletter, and reject reports that should have been 999 calls with a note that says so. The app is a record and a warning system, not a route to the police.

Say who you are. Villages engage with a named person, not an app. Put your name and the fact that you coordinate VillageWatch in the parish newsletter, so residents know who to talk to when they are unsure about reporting something.

Getting help

Email info@yakasista.com. That address reaches the people who run the service. There is no ticketing system and no telephone queue.

Reporting a technical problem. Tell us what you were trying to do, what happened instead, and roughly when. If a screen showed an error, say what it said — but do not send a screenshot of anything containing report text, resident names or original wording. If we need to see the data, we will ask, and we will tell you how to send it safely. Your village name and the report reference (the short code beginning VW) are enough for us to find almost anything.

Requesting a feature. Genuinely welcome, and the requests that come from coordinators actually running villages are the ones that get built. Tell us what you are trying to achieve rather than what button you want, and tell us how often it comes up. "I spend twenty minutes every Monday retyping the week's reports into an email for our PCSO" is a much better request than "please add an export button", and it is the kind that gets a better answer than the one you asked for.

Anything urgent — a data breach, a letter from the Information Commissioner, a resident being harassed through the app — email us the same day and say "urgent" in the subject line.

In an emergency, call 999. VillageWatch is not monitored, is not a route to the police, and nobody is watching the queue at three in the morning. For non-urgent police matters, 101 or your force's website.